

and side-step difficult conversations—we have to own the mistake and make the repair sincere. By taking full responsibility for our actions without being defensive, self-deprecating, or placating the client, we model how to be congruent, present, and unblended. If the client has a part who tries to rescue you from a relational mistake, ask them to help fearful parts relax back so they can speak for any parts who feel angry, hurt, or confused. Mistakes can also, of course, activate our own critics to go on the attack internally. We may have a protective part who:

- Shames us for not being perfect, which interferes with our ability to stay interpersonally connected
- Activates in response to an exile's shamefulness internally and responds by getting angry with the client
- Believes admitting mistakes means we are a bad therapist
- Feels powerless when we are in a one-down position
- Fears that admitting to a mistake will lead to losing the client's respect and losing influence with the client

To overcome these challenges, we suggest making a commitment to exploring your parts going forward and forgiving any part who makes a mistake. In addition, making repairs is an ongoing process that promotes safety, so we ask clients to give us feedback on a regular basis. Finally, get consultation when you need it.

PHASE 3 OF TREATMENT: ENDING

In the last phase of IFIO, we help couples heal wounds and forgive betrayal, which all couples experience at some point. Some betrayals are small and mundane, like poor attunement. Others, like having an affair, can be very consequential. Repeated, unresolved injuries, great and small, cause protective parts to commit even more resources to guarding the heart. As the relationship erodes, the couple comes to view each other as adversaries rather than supports and resources. To recapture trust, they need a safe way to take responsibility for injurious behaviors. In this last phase of therapy, we unpack the experiences, feelings, and beliefs that couples often have regarding betrayal, apology, and forgiveness.

Repair

Oftentimes, individuals struggle to make amends because their protectors are holding onto a variety of distortions that block repair. For example, they may have protectors who associate the experience of apologizing with:

- Accepting undeserved or unbearable blame
 - “It takes two to tango. If I take full responsibility, I’ll be letting her off the hook.”
- Encouraging a variety of future dangers, especially being shamed
 - “When I say that I’m sorry, he uses it against me later.”
- Being chronically deprived of validation in the past, so they insist on being correct now
 - “I’m right, so why should I apologize?”

When protectors promote these distortions, people tend to move on without hearing each other or without ever making a full, genuine repair. They may apologize badly, turn the table and blame the partner, dishonestly self-deprecate, or try to justify their hurtful behavior. Doing any of this will leave wounds festering and encourage the partner’s vigilant protectors to raise the drawbridge. Repair is essential for maintaining intimacy, so in IFIO we challenge avoidant and prickly protectors to try something new. Specifically, we ask them to unblend and meet the Self. If they are not ready to do this, we listen and validate their concerns. But we don’t listen passively. We keep asking for permission to present alternatives, and we keep promising that our offer will be of benefit to protectors, as well as exiles.

When making repairs, we help clients distinguish between shame and guilt. Although both emotions evoke feelings of self-consciousness, they are fundamentally different (Lewis, 1974). Shame involves negative global self-judgments (e.g., “I am bad”), whereas guilt focuses on accepting responsibility for a particular behavior (e.g., “I did wrong”). Although shame is associated with maladaptive, self-destructive behavior (e.g., avoidance, addiction, blame), guilt motivates us to repair and reconnect (e.g., “I transgressed, and I owe you an apology”).

Historically, a lot of writing in the field of mental health has conflated guilt with shame, and many clients follow suit. We find that clients benefit a lot from understanding the difference between the two. Most of us have protective parts who will transgress in a pinch, and doing a U-turn helps us take responsibility for these parts and their actions. Guilt is a cue to assess whether and how we have transgressed. We do not want to reassure clients who feel appropriately guilty. Rather, we want to

help them separate from extreme protectors, hear from the parts who feel guilty, care about the parts who transgressed, and take responsibility for their behavior, including by offering reparation to anyone who has been harmed.

We also don't want to reassure self-critical clients, mostly because doing so has little lasting effect. We all have shaming parts, and they will continue to do their jobs until the underlying parts who feel shameful (i.e., the exiles) are more securely attached to the client's Self and feel better. With this goal, we challenge critical protectors to allow the client's Self to care for exiles in the usual way: helping extreme protectors unblend, having compassion for them, and inviting them to notice their effect on each other and on other people. When a protector can register guilt, the client can make a genuine repair.

Forgiveness

From an IFIO perspective, forgiveness takes time and is different for everyone. It's a process of helping protectors let go so clients can feel sad, grieve, and move on with an open heart. It does *not* involve condoning harmful behavior, letting someone "off the hook" for harmful behavior, ignoring boundaries, or staying in a relationship despite repeated injury. As clients cultivate compassion and come to hold themselves with tenderness, it grows easier to forgive and mend betrayal. However, the more polarized and mistrusting their protectors are, the longer this will take and the more difficult it will be.

Couples who come to therapy after a serious betrayal are often either in a state of collapse (e.g., compliance, withdrawal, depression) or activation (e.g., anger, revenge), or some combination of the two. Underneath the collapse or anger, we find confusion and unhealed injuries from earlier in life. As a result, the first step in forgiveness involves promising protectors that we will focus first on finding vulnerable exiles and helping them not to overwhelm. Then, gently and respectfully, we explore what forgiveness means to each partner personally and to the couple. If protectors allow the Self to access and heal exiles, then their urges to avoid, deny, or take revenge deflate, and partners can grieve.

However, many partners have protectors who fear forgiveness and associate it with unlikely outcomes, such as forgetting the past (e.g., "You mean forgive and forget? I don't want to forget!") and being more vulnerable after having forgiven (e.g., "If I forgive this behavior, then it will happen again. I'll be a sitting duck"). Additionally, protectors sometimes associate forgiveness with alarming outcomes. For example, vengeful parts have to be convinced that it's safe to let go of the idea of retributive justice (e.g., "You're asking me to let him get away with this. He should suffer too!"),

angry parts have to relinquish the physically inflating and emotionally distracting effects of righteousness (e.g., “If I forgive her, I just know I’ll get depressed”), and vigilant parts have to let go of the fear that the client is a child without resources (e.g., “If I don’t protect her, who will?”).

Raising the topic of forgiveness smokes out parts who need reassurance, as well as parts who need help but have remained hidden from view. When the repair process begins, we can predict that partners have shaming parts and parts who feel shameful, and we also need to remember that not every couple sees betrayal the way we do. Every therapist who works with betrayal must be mindful of their own experiences and views on betrayal, especially infidelity. As the therapist, ask yourself:

- What are my beliefs about betrayal?
- How do I view the wounding partner?
- How do I view the wounded partner?
- Are extramarital affairs a symptom, an attempted cure, or neither?
- Does it make a difference to me how the disclosure happened?

Be prepared for your own polarizations to show up when a couple begins to unpack a serious betrayal. In addition, take care to avoid these common mistakes:

- Focusing on the years of discontent or initiating intimacy building before addressing the breach in trust
- Not describing your approach to the repair process with the couple
- Allowing the wounded partner’s outraged protectors to blend and dominate the therapy for too long
- Allowing the wounding partner to blame the wounded partner for past transgressions or ask the wounded partner to take responsibility prematurely
- Pushing forgiveness
- Blending with parts of your own who have an agenda and cause you to lose track of what the couple wants and needs

BETRAYAL, REPAIR, AND FORGIVENESS

Therapists can ask the following IFIO questions to facilitate the last phase of therapy:

- “How are you feeling right now?”

- “What do each of you hope for?”
- “What would a successful outcome look like?”
 - o Listen to their parts.
 - o Gauge how motivated each partner is toward repair at this moment.
- “Have you done repair work with a therapist, a coach, or each other?”
- “Is the behavior ongoing?” (or “Has the affair stopped?”)
- “Have you talked about this? How did it go?”
- “How was this disclosed?”

The IFIO Method with Repair and Forgiveness

Many couples have no blueprint for repairing ruptures, small or large. A conflict or betrayal that isn't mended will ulcerate and burden their relationship, resulting in less trust and less heartfelt connection. The seven steps of repair outlined in this section can be used for all betrayals, big and small, including mundane infractions. A repair can take minutes or years, depending on the couple. The meaning that protective parts hold about the past and the other person, as well as their fear of being hurt and humiliated, are what make apology and forgiveness difficult. But even when partners decide to part ways, forgiving and loving their own parts as well as apologizing to and forgiving each other are transformative.

Although a heartfelt repair can come in many forms, the seven steps presented here focus on increasing each partner's ability to speak for their parts, listen from the heart, empathize with each other's pain, and take responsibility for harmful actions (Herbine-Blank et al. 2016; Springs 2004). While these seven steps are effective for ruptures that range from relational aches and pains to serious betrayals, couples move through them at their own pace, sometimes in a circular rather than a linear fashion, because the process can evoke shame and many parts may need attention along the way. Before leading couples through the seven steps, help the couple by reviewing how the internal system works with a few specific assertions:

- We do not control our parts.
- Our parts can control us when they blend with us.
- Helping parts be willing to unblend is key to being in relationship with them, which is key to progress in therapy.

- We have many parts, and we are vastly more than our most extreme parts.
- Regardless of the cost to others and us, extreme parts view their behavior as protective, essential, and largely non-negotiable.
 - o Proactive protectors (managers) are always trying to manage both external and internal relationships. Despite the costs of their behavior, their intentions are good.
 - o Reactive protectors (firefighters) focus on rapid internal change and have little concern about external consequences. That is, even if their behavior is destructive, their intentions are good—but just for us, not for others.
- We can get to know, understand, and help all extreme parts. They are misguided but not bad.
- We can forgive ourselves fully by taking full responsibility for the actions of our parts.
- Once our protective parts trust us, we can help them by offering to solve their problem, which is the underlying imperative of warding off emotional pain.

In addition, therapists should emphasize the following important assertions about the process and nature of forgiveness. First, individuals can have contradictory ideas about forgiveness. That is, their parts can disagree. In addition, forgiveness does not involve forgetting, nor does it change the transgressor's responsibility for consequences. It does not let anyone off the hook. Rather, forgiving requires that clients exhibit compassion for themselves and their partner. When clients release their anger and resentment in the process of forgiving, they heal and benefit directly.

Once therapists have reviewed these assertions regarding IFS and forgiveness, they are ready to introduce the seven steps of repair. Although we summarize these steps here, we have illustrated them throughout the manual:

- 1. Creating safety for both partners.** In the beginning, the therapist should avoid content in favor of process and never take sides on polarizing issues. Reassure the couple that you can help them both with all types of feelings (e.g., anger, hurt, betrayal, fear, shame).
- 2. Speaking for parts and listening from the heart.** Explain that you aim to help them with internal and external shaming by establishing a new way of speaking and listening. Then teach them to unblend so they can speak on behalf of their parts and listen from the heart.
- 3. Taking full responsibility by means of self-inquiry and self-forgiveness.** At the outset, the wounded partner is the listener and the wounding partner is the speaker. The wounded partner (the listener) helps their parts unblend so they can listen from the heart. The wounding partner (the speaker) notices parts who have caused harm, as well as the

parts who shame them internally for having caused harm, and does a U-turn by helping harming parts (and shaming parts when necessary) unblend. Next, partners switch roles. The wounding partner now listens (from the heart, with help if needed), asking for time to help shaming protectors who activate internally as needed. The wounded partner (now the speaker) also helps protectors unblend and speaks for them about the impact of the wounding partner's behavior.

4. **Reconciling.** To give a sincere apology, the wounding partner—who is now unblended from extreme parts—responds to the wounded partner's impact statement. If their response is shame-based (e.g., "I'm so bad"), the wounding partner's protectors need more help. However, if the response is guilt-based, we know the wounding partner feels genuine remorse for their behavior and their protectors are willing to change. Throughout this process, the wounded partner listens.
5. **Setting an intention.** The wounding partner details their plan to help their parts. The wounded partner listens.
6. **Forgiving.** At this point, we explore the wounded partner's willingness to receive an apology and consider forgiveness. We do not push or pressure the wounded partner to forgive. If the wounded partner refuses to forgive, the other is likely to feel they are being asked to beg for mercy in perpetuity. In this case, we help the unforgiven partner do a U-turn, unblend from reactive parts, and attend to their exiles so they can respond to this outcome in a Self-led way.
7. **Acknowledging unique historical experiences while sharing responsibility.** If the wounded partner does not believe they share responsibility for the conflict, we help them do a U-turn so they can listen to their parts, whose skewed views on responsibility are rooted in history.

Ultimately, we want partners to see their relationship as a co-creation based on the needs of certain exiled parts. The therapy process helps each partner meet the needs of their exiled parts so they can recreate their external relationship on a foundation of mutual curiosity and respect. The wounded partner, however, must be ready for a conversation about mutual responsibility. Depending on how egregious the injury, this can take a long time.

BETRAYAL AND REPAIR

The following case example illustrates the beginning of how we introduce a couple to the process of repair following betrayal. Bob and Judith, a cisgendered, heterosexual, European-American couple in their mid-sixties, had been married for 32 years. Their children were grown. They sought therapy to decide if their marriage could be salvaged after Bob had a series of affairs. The following is an excerpt from their second session with an IFIO therapist.

Therapist: Welcome, I want to hear from both of you about last week's session and how the week went. Who would like to start?

Judith: [*looking at Bob*] Why don't you start for a change?

Bob: I'd prefer not to.

Therapist: [*to Bob*] You prefer not to speak? Can you tell me a little more about that?

Bob: [*lowers his head and sighs*] It doesn't feel safe.

Therapist: I hear you. It doesn't feel safe to speak right now—

Judith: [*interrupting*] But it is safe to have affairs and engage in myriad other bad behaviors?

Therapist: Judith, I am going to interrupt you. A moment ago, you said you would like to hear from Bob. So I'll have a conversation with him, and then the three of us can decide what will be most helpful today. How does that sound?

Redirecting firmly and reframing

Judith: Okay, yes. Thank you. It would be helpful for somebody to have a conversation with him.

Therapist: Bob, last week I introduced the idea of parts. [*he nods*] What I hear is that you have a part who is afraid.

Bob: Many parts of me are afraid!

Therapist: Could you speak for that fear?

Bob: It always ends up in a fight, so it's better not to speak.

Therapist: That is what you hear yourself saying to yourself? "I am safer if I don't speak"?

Bob: Yes. And that's my pattern too.

Therapist: The pattern is you stay quiet?

Bob: Right.

Therapist: And since you are becoming more aware of your pattern, are you also aware of what happens inside Judith when you don't speak?

Bob: She gets mad.

Therapist: Okay. I'm hearing that some of your parts feel unsafe if you speak, but then Judith gets mad, so there's no win for you. Am I getting it right?

Bob: You are.

Therapist: We'll return to your dilemma, but right now I'm going to check in with Judith. [*to Judith*] What's happening for you?

Judith: I feel hopeless. I'll never get what I want or need.

Therapist: If I'm hearing you right, you're in touch with parts who feel sad and hopeless. But you're less in touch with the anger you spoke for last week?

Judith: To tell the truth, I'm mostly angry. It's safer that way.

Therapist: That makes sense. But in this moment, you are also in touch with hopelessness and despair and the belief that you will never get what you want or need from Bob.

Validating and reflecting back

Judith: That's right. That's exactly right.

Therapist: Bob, what happens in you when you hear this?

Bob: I feel like it's just better to get out of here. She may be sad or whatever, but she's waiting to unload years of anger and resentment. I've heard it so many times, I'm not available to hear it again.

Therapist: And that makes sense to me as well.

Validating, which supports unblending

Bob: Thank you for that.

Therapist: I understand from last week that you, Judith, have a part who gets understandably angry and that you, Bob, have a part who understandably turns away. And I hear that you, Judith, have been experiencing Bob's distancing—among other things—for years.

Judith: Thank you for that. Yes, among other things! There's a lot of history here.

Therapist: While both of you have parts who want to be heard and understood, this impasse I'm hearing about right now is what actually happens. Anger and hopelessness with an inability to have the conversations you really need to have. Am I getting this right? [*they nod*]

Checking for accuracy and using parts language

Therapist: [*continuing*] I know you are coming to see me after seeing several other therapists, and I want to ask once more, what is the hope of trying therapy again?

Listening to the hopes of the parts who made the decision to come to therapy

Bob: I'm not sure. I guess I still hope something might change.

Therapist: What would that be?

Looking for clarity that will help this phase of therapy move forward

Bob: I don't really know. Maybe it would be like getting past all the anger to something that look like a relationship?

Therapist: And when you say, "the anger," do you mean your anger as well as Judith's?

Bob: Oh yes.

Therapist: Bob, I hear you acknowledging that you, too, are angry and that this impasse involves a back and forth of anger and resentment. You have parts who pull you in different ways, including into affairs.

Bob: Yes, that's true.

Therapist: And Judith, what is your hope for trying therapy again?

Judith: My hope is that he would stop the affairs and all the things he does that tell me he doesn't love me.

Therapist: I hear that you wish Bob would do things differently, and you wish to feel loved by him. And I am also aware of parts who are willing to try therapy with yet another therapist. If this could be successful, what outcome would you want for yourself or for the relationship?

Judith: I want to see if we want to be together.

Therapist: I'm curious. [*looking from one to the other*] Between the time you sat down here and now, what has been happening in your bodies? What are you experiencing?

Checking for ANS regulation and unblending

Judith: [*a long sigh*] I'm calmer, less tense. [*pauses*] I think I can actually hear more of what you're saying. I was so upset when I sat down that I couldn't concentrate. I wonder if you are trying to figure out if you can help us?

Therapist: I believe I can help you.

Judith: So you're wondering if we want help?

Therapist: Exactly. I'm guessing, Judith, that as you're feeling a little calmer, your brain is able to take in and process more information?

Judith: True.

Bob: I notice something just shifted a little in me. I feel a tiny bit hopeful. It feels very risky to say but I do. I'm also wondering if Judith will take responsibility for her part of what's wrong with our relationship.

Therapist: Bob, I want to slow down for a moment and be curious about what just happened. First, I heard you take a risk and say something very vulnerable. Then, right after that, I heard another part say something about Judith.

Bob: So I have done a lot of things in this relationship that have been really hurtful. I admit it, but I am not the only one.

Therapist: So you don't want to be the only bad one. Is that right?

Bob: That's exactly right.

Therapist: And I think I'm hearing that you have a part who believes you're the bad one.

Returning to parts language

Bob: Most definitely.

Therapist: And what's that like, to feel like the bad one?

Bob: Not fun.

Therapist: And is that part here right now?

Bob: Yes, I feel it all over. Very shameful.

Therapist: And does it make sense that even as you experience one part's shamefulness, another part wants to distract you and make sure Judith shares the discomfort? [*Bob pauses to think, then nods*]

Pointing out the pairing of protectors with exiles

Therapist: [*continuing*] So I want to reassure those parts. If you choose to continue couple therapy with me, we will eventually get into the entire history of your relationship. But for this moment, I want to stay with what's happening here and now. [*turns to Judith*] What's happening for you as you listen?

Judith: [*a long pause*] I'm trying to believe what Bob is saying. He wants me to take responsibility, but I want him to take responsibility. He acknowledges that he has done a lot to damage our relationship.

Therapist: What is it like in this moment to hear Bob acknowledge that he has hurt you?

Judith: It's good and bad. On the one hand, the acknowledgment feels good. On the other hand, it just brings up all that hurt and anger. I don't like thinking or hearing about it. The affairs, the other women...

Therapist: It sounds, Bob, like you have made some choices, affairs being one of them, that have been very hurtful. I'm curious if any other therapies have offered to help you repair that damage?

Bob: [*shakes his head*] Maybe, but I don't remember it.

Judith: I don't even know what you're talking about. What are you talking about?

Therapist: I'll tell you what I believe. When a betrayal leaves one person feeling deeply hurt, the injury needs to be healed before they can think about what was happening in the relationship before the betrayal. I believe this is critical.

Judith: We haven't heard this before. [*looking at Bob*] Not that I remember.

Bob: Me neither. But it makes sense. [*sighs*]

Therapist: Can you tell me about that sigh, Bob?

Bob: Well, maybe you can handle us! Maybe you can actually help.

Therapist: So maybe I can sit with all the hurt and be present to the suffering in your relationship and help you heal?

Judith: What you offer is clearly different. There has been damage. We do need repair.

Note the passive voice—Judith is not ready to consider her role in any damage

Therapist: Repair is an optimistic goal, and I'd like to tell you a little about the repair process I use.

Offering to give them a brief description of the IFIO repair process

Judith: That would be good.

Bob: Yes, I would like to hear that.

Therapist: I expect you will have some difficult conversations, but I can teach you a new way of speaking and listening to each other so you don't fall into shaming and blaming, or collapsing and running away. I can teach you to speak for your parts and listen from the heart. For you, Bob, this will involve listening as Judith describes the impact of your affairs. And I will keep the process as safe as possible. I would want you to be able to empathize with Judith, feel remorse, and discover what Judith needs in order to heal. Your inquiry would include looking at and taking responsibility for the choices your parts made on your behalf, as well as understanding and addressing their motivations. And you, Judith. You have parts who are very angry, hurt, humiliated, hopeless, and scared. Am I right?

Judith: You are so right. I feel all those things. But when I start feeling too vulnerable, I rage. It's better.

Therapist: I understand that raging feels empowering. My approach with parts who need that would be somewhat different. I would want you to be able to express every feeling you have but to do it in a way that Bob can hear. His parts need to understand their impact and be willing to hand the reins back to him so he can take responsibility and make repairs.

Judith: That's what I want too! Part of the raging is to make sure he gets that. I believe he hasn't gotten it yet.

Therapist: As long as his parts are defending against your rage, I'm not sure he can truly hear you.

Judith: [long pause] I don't really want to help him out. But I do want something to shift. Nothing else has worked. So I am going to go with your idea.

Therapist: Great. And I will be here to help you all along the way. Both of you.

Letting them know the plan and offering ongoing help

Judith: Knowing that you will help us along the way makes my whole body relax.

Bob: Mine too.

Judith: [turning to Bob] I need to know that you won't have any more affairs. If you do, I'll leave.

Bob: [looking at Judith] I do understand this, Judith.

Therapist: Once things begin to shift, we can work on reconciliation and forgiveness.

Judith: [puts up her hands] Oh, I'm not ready to forgive!

Therapist: That makes sense to me. We'll discuss forgiveness later, if and when you're both ready. There will be no pressure about forgiving. Right now, we'll focus on changing your conversation and work toward a sincere repair.

Alleviating any pressure to forgive

Therapist: [continuing] I notice you're looking at Bob.

Judith: I'm curious if he agrees with what you're saying.

Bob: Doing something different would be good.

Judith: So we agree on something! [*Bob nods and Judith laughs*] We agree! Wow.

Therapist: I appreciate you wanting to do something different. I know this has been hard, and you wonder what more could shift.

Bob: I'll be honest. This scares me. I am willing to give it a try, but I don't know if I can do it. I still don't want to be the target of all blame and anger.

Therapist: Of course you don't. But when I said some of these conversations will involve listening to the impact of your behavior on Judith, you did nod.

Bob: Yes. And I also want Judith to hear me about how some of her choices early in our relationship affected me. Like her anger.

Therapist: Of course Judith has hurt some of your parts over the 32 years of your marriage.

Bob: [*teary*] This is the first time anyone has acknowledged that. It's powerful. Thank you.

Therapist: And I believe this rupture in the present needs to be healed before we explore all the ways you have hurt each other over the course of your marriage. Does what I'm proposing make sense?

Bob: I get that, absolutely.

Therapist: Would you be willing to say what you get, right now, directly to Judith?

*Reinforcing moments of connection when
the opportunity arises*

Bob: [*inhales sharply*] That's scary. [*looks at Judith*] I know if we're going to get anywhere, I have to hear what you feel about what I did. And I have to take much more responsibility.

Therapist: What's it like to hear that, Judith?

Judith: [*pauses*] I have goosebumps. [*looks at Bob*] It's a game changer. I never heard you say anything like that. Is it real?

Bob: It's real.



Needless to say, this was just the beginning. Bob began individual therapy and got to know the parts who chose to have affairs in response to his loneliness, anger toward Judith, and loss of joy in his life. Over time, he understood how his inner dilemmas and his childhood trauma had contributed to this behavior, and he was able to listen to Judith without defending himself. Once he became more hopeful, believing he could heal, and their relationship could survive, he was able to apologize to Judith with genuine remorse.

Over time, as Judith experienced the power of speaking for her devastated parts without raging, she gained trust in herself and was able to be curious about what had led to Bob feeling so resentful and hostile toward her earlier in their relationship. However, until they were less reactive, and their relationship was kinder and gentler—with more moments of connection and fun—the topic of forgiveness was off the table. Therapists can use the following handouts with clients in order to learn and practice repair processes, which are a critical step in unburdening from past hurts and betrayals, healing relationships, and reclaiming trust.

Client Handout

THE IFIO Do-Over:

Catch Your Protector in Action and Try Again

A *do-over* is a quick repair. As we befriend protectors and become aware of harm they have caused, it gets easier to notice when we are misattuned or unkind to our partner and interrupt the cycle by apologizing and asking to *redo* the interaction in a Self-led way. We outline the steps of a communication *do-over* here:

1. Acknowledge your misattunement or unkindness.
2. Ask your partner if they will stay with you so you can *redo* the communication.
3. Wait for their agreement.
4. Try again by speaking *for* your part, and then take time to notice and speak for the part's underlying (exiled) need.
5. Check in with your partner. What do they hear from their parts?
6. Listen from the Self.

Here is an example:

1. A frustrated part takes aim: "I've asked you over and over not to do that!"
2. The do-over: "I'm sorry I lashed out. I don't want to talk like that. May I try again?"
3. Wait for partner's affirmative response.
4. Then: "I have a part who feels frustrated when this happens repeatedly. I wonder if we could talk about the pattern at some point?"
5. Check in: "Did that land differently for you? Is there anything you want to say?"

6. Listen to the impact of your behavior without defensiveness.

* We thank Michele Bograd, PhD, for her contributions to the ideas and observations in this section. We have paraphrased some of her thinking throughout what follows.